

Introduction

Women's impact on the world is a story that has slowly been coming to light over the past century. Through history, female warriors and queens have conquered foreign lands, female explorers have pushed back frontiers, and women artists, writers, and activists have changed prevailing attitudes and views. The problem is that in the patriarchal (male-ruled) societies that dominate the world, women's stories of the resistance they have faced and obstacles they have overcome have been marginalized, and have not always been told.

Women in history

It is thought that the sidelining of women by men began around 12,000 years ago. At the dawn of human history, during the Stone Age, early humans lived in hunter-gatherer societies, in which both men and women played a vital and complementary role. However, this changed with the Neolithic Revolution, when humans began to shift from nomadic to geographically-settled societies based on agriculture, which was controlled by men. As populations expanded, women's contributions to food production diminished and men began to place restrictions and controls on women, regulating their behavior through institutions such as marriage, religion, and law.

In ancient civilizations such as those in China, Greece, Egypt, and Rome, the vast majority of women had far fewer freedoms than men. Despite this, women had status in the household and as mothers, and some became priestesses associated with goddesses in polytheistic religions. However, by the medieval era, when monotheism became dominant, particularly in the West and Near East, the spiritual role of women dwindled. Customs and laws created by men continued to limit the role of most medieval women.

Despite this, a number of queens and empresses across the world showed that women could be effective leaders.

The early modern era, from the 18th century, gave rise to western imperialism, which saw colonial powers impose their own concepts of gender roles on societies in the Americas, Africa, Asia, and Australasia, dislodging indigenous customs. At the same time, women participated in the waves of reformation and revolution that created the modern world. Over the course of the 19th century, as a result of the Industrial Revolution, the economic role of women shifted, and they entered the workplace in greater numbers. Working women, who contributed to the wealth of both their families and the wider society, demanded the same rights as men. Feminism began to emerge as a global movement, and women agitated for greater freedoms, including the right to vote.

Women made a major contribution to the world wars of the first half of the 20th century, which also boosted their place in society. By the second-half of the century the role of women had been transformed—but there was still work to be done. The second and third waves of feminism, from the 1960s to the present day, have seen women campaign on a huge range of issues, including divorce and contraception, as well as LGBTQ rights, in the effort to break down traditional barriers and finally dislodge the patriarchy. At last, women's voices are being heard.

► Wise woman

This 6th-century mosaic in Ravenna, Italy, shows Empress Theodora, one of the most influential figures of the Eastern Roman Empire.

